

Wii 2 update

Will the new Wii feature controllers with a 6 inch screen? It's also rumoured to have eight buttons, two analog sticks and a camera

New Harry Potter game

New instalment in the Harry Potter franchise will debut a day before the movie is released

Top Spin 4

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2K Czech, and what is left of PAM development, have returned with next installment in the Top Spin series after a hiatus of nearly three years. By far, the most significant change (or improvement) with the latest iteration is the control system. Since there were sizeable bunch of gamers that found Top Spin 3's control scheme hard to master, the developers have overhauled the system to create something that scales very well.

There is a good deal of content squeezed onto the disc, with a roster that boasts about 17 active professional players, along with eight retired legends of the sport. Additionally, there are also seven tournaments and a total of 36 venues. The game has a single-player career mode, an online World Tour mode via PSN, and an offline party-mode called 'King of the Court', wherein the winner stays back and a new challenger takes over the second controller.

Elegant control

In my opinion, the most elegant feature of Top Spin 4 is its intuitive and adaptable control system. For those who find the more advanced concept of this sport a bit

esoteric, the game can be effectively played using a single button and the directional controls. This kind

of game-play is perfectly suited for a casual match against an opponent of equal skills. However, bringing down the likes of Djokovic and Federer requires use of various spins and shot modifiers to exploit the opponent's weaknesses. Without going into the game's menu system, a player can decide to go for some more advanced shots in the middle of a match. Within the same control system, holding down a face button for a specific period will set up a power shot; whereas hitting the same button right before swigging unleashes a controlled shot with deadly precision.

Taking center court

The game's single-player career mode is quite a satisfying experience and a fulfilling way of honing game-skills. This mode starts with the rigmarole of avatar creation and customization options like facial appearance, sports gear, playing style (Serve and Volley, Offensive Base-

line and Defensive Baseline) and a couple of animation choices. A bit of nice touch in the Career Mode are coaches who task the player to complete certain objectives before providing benefits like skill boosts and special abilities. This, along with completing matches, is rewarded with experience points that go towards increasing the player's level. Player's skills are passively increased when selecting one of three playing styles after each level-up. Character progression is a choice between focusing on a single playing style or distributing points across different styles to avoid any glaring weaknesses. Players level-up at a fairly brisk pace, which is an added incentive to create multiple players with varying combinations of playing styles. The game's AI is quite timid, until the player reaches the top leagues with Grand Slams and World Championships. This actually works to the game's benefit as the AI scales in tandem with character progression. So by the time the big tournaments become available, the player is maxed out at level 20 with a fully unlocked, top-notch coach.

Top Spin 4 is a pretty solid tennis simulation in spite of a couple of shortcomings, which makes the game easy to recommend. However, with a new Vitua Tennis just around the corner, you might want to hold on for a few days. 

8.5
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